MASTER BRIEF · VERSION 1.0 · 23 OCTOBER 2026

Master Website Brief

How to plan, design, build, edit and prove a professional website: calm editorial clarity, purposeful spatial motion and an editor anyone can use. For any designer, developer or AI.

Starting point: *Website Design Research: Editorial clarity, spatial motion, purposeful products* (22 October 2026), five live references, observed and proposed.

Proven on: a complete 31-page website and content editor built and reviewed in one project, with every motion value measured, tested and corrected by the site owner.

Status words: RULE = must follow · DEFAULT = start here, change with a reason · AVOID = tried and rejected · CHECK = verify before launch.

00 / CONTENTS

What is in this brief

01 How to use this brief
02 Decisions: what survived the build
03 Ten principles
04 Lessons taught in review
05 Discovery, facts and content
06 Visual system
07 Page architecture and storytelling
08 Motion system
09 Layout stability
10 The content editor (CMS)
11 Responsive behaviour
12 Accessibility and reduced motion
13 Performance, security, hosting and previews
14 Implementation contract
15 Process and review rounds
16 Acceptance checklist
17 Paste-ready prompt for an AI
18 Sources and limits

01 / How to use this brief

Order of authority. (1) The client's words in the current request. (2) The client's brand system and approved facts. (3) This brief. (4) The builder's own taste. When two instructions conflict, name the conflict and ask which wins. Never pick one silently.

Fits: any site that has to explain something real (an organisation, a product range, a service, a school, a studio) and still feel memorable. **Does not fit:** pure web apps, dashboards or long documentation, which need utility over atmosphere.

Deliver with every build: a responsive implementation; design tokens in one file; a component map; a motion trigger table (effect, trigger, values, fallback); a content editor with drafts, preview, roles and versions; database migrations; an editor guide; a sources register for facts and images; disclosure of anything unfinished, placeholder or unverified; and evidence for every item in chapter 16.

> **Never invent facts.** Names, numbers, prices, dates, results, awards and claims come only from client-supplied sources. Anything awaiting confirmation is labelled in the content and listed in the sources register. Use the client's real photographs. Stock or generated images are used only when the client approves them, and are labelled as such.

How to read the status words

Each rule carries a status. `RULE` means it must be followed, `DEFAULT` means start here and change it with a reason, `AVOID` means it was tried and rejected, and `CHECK` means verify it before launch. In chapter 02, `KEEP`, `CHANGED`, `DROPPED` and `NEW` mark what happened to each research idea once it was built.

02 / DECISIONS

What survived contact with a real build

The research recommended a combination: Floema's clarity, Inertia's interaction language and selected signature effects. Each idea was then built, shown to the site owner and kept, changed or dropped.

Reference idea	Research proposal	Verdict	What to do now
Spatial explorer (spiral of images)	6–10 images on a shallow helix; wheel and drag; prev/next and a list mode.	CHANGED	Keep the helix. Drive it by *reading* page scroll plus drag and arrow keys; no visible prev/next or list buttons (owner: "just make the picture interactive"). Caption in a fixed two-line slot.
Same, for text items	None.	NEW	A "term spiral" turns cards of icon + term + one-line tagline as the section pins. Useful for values, principles and features.
Titles stack, separate, exit sideways	Stack → spread → side exit → settle over 1.5–2 viewports.	DROPPED	Built and rejected as too fast and busy. Replace with a **lit statement**: the section holds still while each word brightens in turn with an underline.
Down → across → down chapter	Native scroll pin; x = −D·p; skip link; stack on mobile.	KEEP	Keep the model. Measure D against the content box, align to the content edge, pin only when D > 0, and use a native snap-scrolling row (not a stack) when not pinned.
Shared small responses	One text roll, one arrow swap, one image emphasis, one headline reveal.	KEEP	As proposed. Headline reveal is a soft word fade, once. Nothing re-animates on every scroll.
Moving text band	Slow loop with pause.	KEEP	Only for decorative repetition, never essential information; pause control; static with reduced motion.
Masked / clip reveals	Clip-path reveals for media.	DROPPED	A full clip hid images so lazy loading never fired (blank spaces in Safari). Use opacity and scale reveals.
Purpose-led storytelling	Outcome → object in environment → name and benefit → route → detail → evidence.	KEEP	The backbone of every page (chapter 07).
Warm off-white palette, one acid accent	Ink, cream canvas, one light accent.	CHANGED	Palette comes from the client's brand file, by role (chapter 06). Cream is not a default.
Generous spacing (to 144px)	8px base up to 144.	CHANGED	The owner found it too empty. Section spacing 48–104px.
Ambient atmosphere	Not specified.	NEW	When the owner wants the site to "feel alive", add *background* motion: faint oversized labels drifting slowly, gentle photo parallax, sticky asides. Do not move the text being read.
Long text	Not specified.	NEW	"Read more" with a round down arrow for long passages; a scroll-cue arrow under the hero.

Ten principles

1 **Understand before spectacle.** A calm grid, clear words and real photographs carry the information. Motion adds meaning or atmosphere and is never the only route to content.

2 **Few signatures, well made.** At most one signature scene per page (a spatial gallery, a sideways chapter or a lit statement), separated by calm content. On small sites, choose one main signature.

3 **Motion lives in the background.** Text stays still once it is read. Energy comes from slow ambient layers, image depth and well-made reveals, not from moving headings.

4 **Nothing jumps.** Animated components reserve their space. Swapping a caption, card or counter must never move the rest of the page.

5 **Everything visible, everything loaded.** No content depends on a reveal firing. No image is left unloaded because an effect hid it.

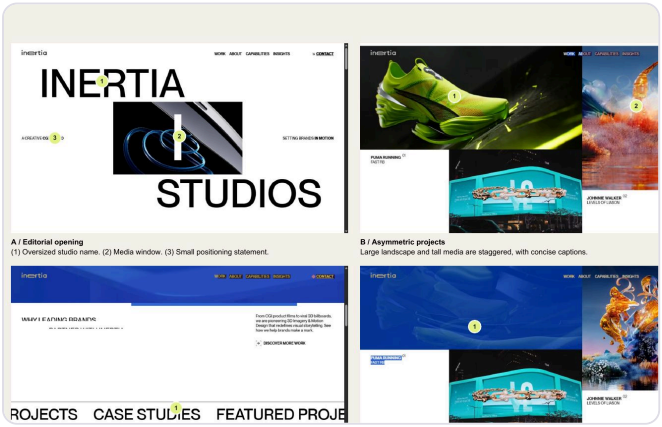
6 **Every control goes somewhere.** No dead links and no "page not found" from navigation. Features that need a server explain themselves in previews.

7 **Less text, better text.** Lead with what the reader needs. Scanned lists get icon + name + one line. Long passages get "Read more".

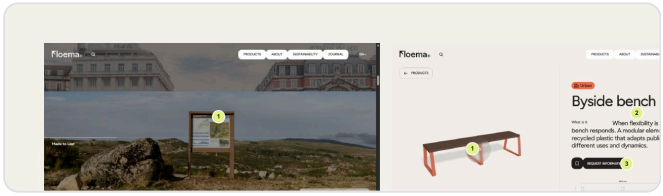
8 **Accessible by construction.** Semantic HTML first; keyboard and screen-reader parity; a designed reduced-motion version of every scene.

9 **Editors are users too.** Every visual option is a plain choice in the editor, with drafts, live preview, roles and version history.

10 **Prove it, then show it.** Automated tests, accessibility scans, overflow checks at every width, and link and image crawls before anything is shared. Report results honestly, failures included.



Research reference: a shared language of small responses (text roll, arrow swap, image emphasis, moving band).



Research reference: purpose-led storytelling. The object in its environment, then name, purpose and action.

04 / LESSONS TAUGHT IN REVIEW

What the site owner taught, as rules

Each row is feedback a site owner gave while reviewing a live build, why it happened, and the rule that now applies to every project.

Owner said	Why it happened	Rule from now on
"Why are there arrows and an All photos button? Just make the picture interactive."	Visible controls made the signature feel like a widget.	**RULE** Spatial galleries are driven by scroll and drag, with keyboard arrows when focused. Show a one-line hint, not buttons.
"The description goes to two lines and shifts the whole page."	Variable-length text inside an animated component.	**RULE** Captions and counters sit in fixed-height slots (line clamp) on fixed grid rows. Test by cycling every state.
"Use the spiral, less text and icons for each."	Lists were read as paragraphs, not scanned.	**RULE** Values, features and principles: icon + term + one line. Full descriptions stay in the editor for a grid view.
"Make part of the page scroll right instead of down."	Wants a directional change.	**DEFAULT** One sideways chapter per page, for 3–6 comparable items.
"The left part is cut off and isn't a real way to scroll."	Overflow was measured against the padded box; on wide screens the row neither pinned nor scrolled.	**RULE** Measure against the content box, align to the content edge, pin only if it overflows, otherwise a native snap row.
"Add more animations, make the page feel alive."	Static pages felt flat.	Add ambient and reveal motion in the background (chapter 08), never by moving the text being read.
"Too much animation; headings move randomly to the side."	Scroll-linked sideways headings strain the eyes.	**AVOID** Moving headings with scroll. **RULE** Headings fade up once; ambient motion goes to faint background labels.
"The word animation isn't good and plays too fast."	Stack, spread and exit choreography was busy and short.	**RULE** Lit statements: words brighten in turn over about 1.6 extra viewport heights; nothing slides.
"There's a lot of empty space." / "Some images don't load."	A clip-path curtain kept lazy images unloaded in Safari; the spacing scale was too generous.	**AVOID** Fully clipping or hiding images. **RULE** Eager-load images inside moving scenes; section spacing 48–104px.
"I'm stuck on a full white page."	Page transitions and page-enter animations stall in embedded viewers.	**AVOID** View transitions and whole-page enter animations unless tested in every container the client uses.
"Many buttons just say no page exists."	Links drawn by script pointed to server routes the preview lacked.	**RULE** Crawl every link, including script-opened menus and search results. Previews map routes; server-only features explain themselves.
"Some buttons don't work and it loads too slowly."	Script paths broke in the hosted copy; many parallel image requests.	**CHECK** Test the exact shared link, not just localhost. Retry dropped images; size images responsively.
"The top scroll indicator colour is ugly, muted and dark."	A multi-hue gradient turned muddy between hues.	**RULE** Indicators use one saturated brand colour, optionally with a soft glow.

Owner said	Why it happened	Rule from now on
"There's a collision" (lines across a button)	The focus ring of an invisible jump target was drawn.	**RULE** Programmatic jump and skip targets: zero height, `outline: none`.
"Clicking at the bottom should open the new page at the top."	Scroll position carried over between page loads.	**RULE** New pages open at the top unless the link names a section.
"Like how some people's heads move down" (a sticky portrait)	Sticky asides felt calm and alive, but only worked where the aside was shorter than the text.	**RULE** Sticky aside columns must be shorter than the text beside them: compact heading, longer text opening.
"Have down arrows when there's a lot of text."	Long passages needed a cue and a choice.	**RULE** "Read more" with a round down arrow over about 1,100 characters; a scroll cue under the hero.
"Give me the editor's version" / "Can't anyone just go to /admin?"	Owners need to see and trust the editor.	**RULE** Ship an editor tour of real screens, plus a plain explanation of sign-in, roles, lockout and how to restrict access.
"I want to actually see the site, not images."	Screenshots don't let people test anything.	**RULE** Always give a working, clickable preview (a hosted build or a verified static copy) as well as screenshots.

Start from what is true

Inputs to request before designing

Brand	Official logo files (SVG), colour values, typefaces and licences, existing guidelines.
Facts	Every claim the site may make, with its source and owner: names, numbers, prices, dates, results, addresses, contacts.
Structure	Audiences and their top tasks; the information architecture (pages, parents, navigation labels); legacy URLs to redirect.
Media	Real photographs with release status and alt-text context; video if any; documents (PDFs).
Operations	Who edits what (roles); where forms should go (email, CRM webhook); analytics and consent requirements; hosting constraints.
Direction	Reference sites and what the client likes in each; any visual "don'ts"; the devices and viewers they will review on (for example an iPad inside an app).

Facts register

RULE Keep a sources document listing every fact, where it came from, its owner and its status (approved, awaiting confirmation). Content awaiting confirmation is visibly labelled on the page. Results and figures carry a year label.

Writing for the site

- Headings describe the content ("How to apply", not "Your journey begins"). Link text makes sense on its own.
- Lead with the reader's need; short paragraphs; scanned lists are icon + name + one line; long passages get "Read more".
- Dates and times in one human format ("Saturday 14 November 2026", "9:00am – 11:00am").
- Alternative text describes what is happening and never names private individuals or children.
- No personal data of minors or clients in content.

Questions to ask, and when not to

Ask when the answer changes what gets built (a missing fact, a brand rule, a conflict between instructions). Don't ask for things with a sensible default; state the default and proceed. When the owner says "your call", choose, explain briefly and keep the choice reversible in the editor.

06 / VISUAL SYSTEM

Tokens by role, filled from the brand

Define tokens once and derive everything from them. Colours are defined by *role*; the client's brand fills the roles. Take values from the official logo file, not from screenshots.

Ink / primary
Headings, primary buttons, dark bands.

Accent
Eyebrows, focus ring, progress, links.

Highlight
Banners, underlines, focus on dark.

Secondary accents
Category cues, always with a text label.

Text / muted
Body and secondary text.

Tint
Alternate bands; avoid default cream.

Lines
Hairlines and borders.

Error
Error text and borders only.

RULE Body text at least 4.5:1, large text at least 3:1, including text over photographs. Muted text on dark bands stays at least 4.5:1, so check it as you dim. Never convey meaning by colour alone. Light accents (yellow, lime) are for graphics or carry dark text.

Token	Default	Notes
Typefaces	Brand display face (600–700) + neutral sans for body (400–600).	Self-host at build time; no runtime font requests; licensed or open fonts only.
Type scale	Display 40→104px · H1 36→72 · H2 30→56 · H3 20→28 · Lead 18→22 · Body 16→18 (line 1.6) · Meta at least 13.	Fluid `clamp()` from 320 to 1440px; headings use `text-wrap: balance` and a `ch` max width.
Container and gutters	Max 1440px; gutters clamp(20px, 4vw, 64px); gaps 16→24px.	12 columns on desktop, 4 on mobile; split headers 7/5; asides 4/7.
Section spacing	48→104px.	Alternate plain and tinted bands to separate chapters without extra space.
Spacing scale	4px base: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48, 64, 96.	Use layout gap, not stacked margins.
Shape	Radius 8 small, 12 buttons and cards, 16–20 photographs; pills only for chips.	Shadows only on raised layers (menus, dialogs, banners).
Buttons	Primary (ink), secondary (outline), light (on dark); joined icon and label.	At least 44px tall; the label states the action.

Originality

Use the client's own images, words and proportions. Extract *relationships* from references (stable labels against moving imagery, compressed text against open space, objects in their environment) rather than copying branded layouts, fonts or code.

07 / PAGE ARCHITECTURE

Explain, show, prove, act

Home page flow

1. **Promise + spatial hero.** One sentence of outcome, two actions, the spiral gallery of real photographs, and a down-arrow scroll cue. About one viewport tall.
2. **Fact strip.** Three or four verified facts.
3. **Progression chapter.** The one sideways chapter: a real sequence (stages, product family, process).
4. **Purposeful showcases.** A feature mosaic of three to five areas, each linking to its page.
5. **Lit statement.** Two to four words that define the brand.
6. **Evidence.** Stories, results, testimonials, process.
7. **Direct action.** Visit, enquire, buy or contact, with addresses.

Interior page template

Hero (page, compact or category variant) → introduction → two to five content sections from the block library → related links → one call-to-action band. Breadcrumbs below the top level. Each audience reaches its top task within one click of the home page.

Block library (default set)

Openers	Hero (home with spatial gallery, page with photo, category with label and colour, compact); Fact strip; Notice.
Narrative	Text (aside, narrow or statement; becomes a sticky letter with a signature and portrait); Image and text; Feature mosaic; Lit statement; Word band.
Lists	Terms (grid with descriptions, or spiral of icon + term + tagline); Link cards (grid or sideways row); Numbered steps (list or sideways row); Grouped lists; Table.
Media and people	Gallery with accessible viewer; People; Documents and resources.
Dynamic	Latest stories; Upcoming events (auto-hide when past); FAQ list (deep links); Locations with consent-gated maps; Pricing or admissions information from one source.
Action	Enquiry form; Call-to-action band; Reusable section (edited once, placed many times).

Site-wide essentials

Sticky header with click-to-open menus, a mobile menu dialog and search; a footer with contacts and policies; a sticky mobile primary action; a cookie banner with Accept, Reject and Customise; a search results page that works without JavaScript; a helpful 404; a sitemap, robots file, metadata and structured data; redirects from legacy URLs.

08 / MOTION SYSTEM

Three levels, one owner, calm by default

Level 1 is feedback (150–300ms). **Level 2** is reveals and ambient motion (450–900ms, or tied to scroll position). **Level 3** is the signature scenes: at most one per page. One frame-throttled scroll listener owns every scroll-driven effect. Native scrolling only: no smooth-scroll libraries and no wheel capture.

Effect	Trigger	Starting values (proven)	Fallback
Spatial gallery	Reads page scroll (1 item per ~160px while on screen); drag (8px threshold); arrow keys when focused.	6–10 items on a helix: radius 50% of stage, ~36° apart, rise 3%; damping time constant ~90ms; cards 40% wide; depth dims and desaturates; tilt ≤2°.	Reduced motion: keys and drag, instant. A semantic list with alt text and a live caption.
Term spiral	Section pins; 0.5 viewport heights per card; counter, progress, Skip.	Radius 75% of stage, ~30° apart; damping ~110ms; cards with icon, number, term, tagline.	Below ~900×640 or reduced motion: keyboard-focusable snap row.
Sideways chapter	Outer height 100vh + D; x = −D·p.	Cards clamp(280px, 27vw, 400px) from the content edge; no easing on the track; progress line, Skip.	D ≤ 0, below 1024×640, or reduced motion: native snap row.
Lit statement	Section holds; words light between 10% and 80% of travel.	Total travel ~260vh; muted (still ≥4.5:1) → full colour; underline scaleX 0→1; one decorative shape turns ≤6°.	All lit, not pinned.
Heading reveal	Once, on entry.	Words fade and rise 0.25em, 900ms, 40ms stagger; the heading box never moves.	Static.
Media reveal	Once, on entry.	Opacity 0→1, scale 1.035→1, 560ms, 70ms stagger; images stay laid out and loaded.	Immediate.
Photo parallax	While on screen.	±28–48px against scroll; image enlarged 12% so edges never show.	None.
Background label	While on screen.	Section label at 3.5–10rem, ~4.5% opacity, behind the heading, ±70px sideways; CSS-generated.	Hidden under 768px; static with reduced motion.
Sticky aside	Native sticky.	Top = header height + 24px; aside shorter than the text.	Stacked on mobile.
Read more / scroll cue	Text over ~1,100 characters; under the hero.	Opens at ~26rem with a fade mask; 44px round arrow nudges every ~2s; `aria-expanded`.	Without JavaScript: full text.
Progress line	Page scroll.	4px, one saturated accent, soft glow.	Same.
Links, buttons, cards	Hover = focus.	Text roll and arrow swap 220–320ms cubic-bezier(.22,1,.36,1); icon nudge 3px; image ≤1.03.	Colour and underline.

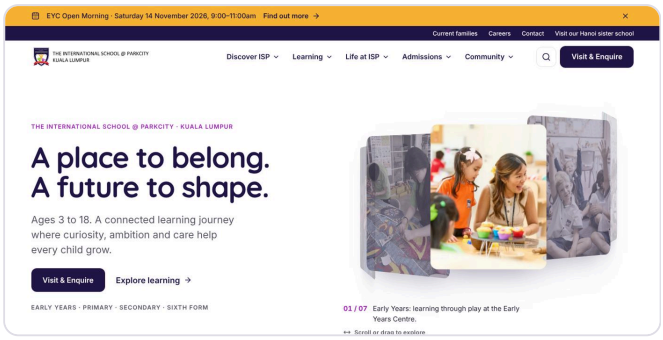
Effect	Trigger	Starting values (proven)	Fallback
Band	On screen; pause on hover, focus, button.	20–35px/s; duplicate hidden from assistive technology.	One static line.
Overlays	Menu, search, settings, viewer.	Native modal dialog; 320ms fade and 12px rise; Escape closes; focus returns.	Instant.

Avoid list. Scroll-linked sideways headings; stack, spread and exit title choreography; clip-path curtains that fully hide images; reveals that leave content hidden if a script fails; cross-document page transitions and page-enter transforms; multi-hue progress bars; visible gallery control clutter; autoplay without a pause control; custom cursors that hide the native one; WebGL where CSS 3D is enough.

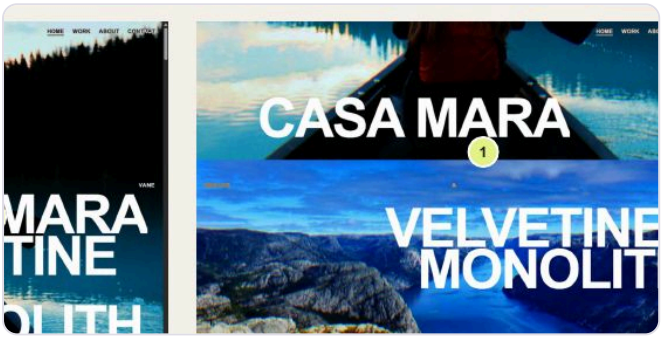
From research reference to built scene



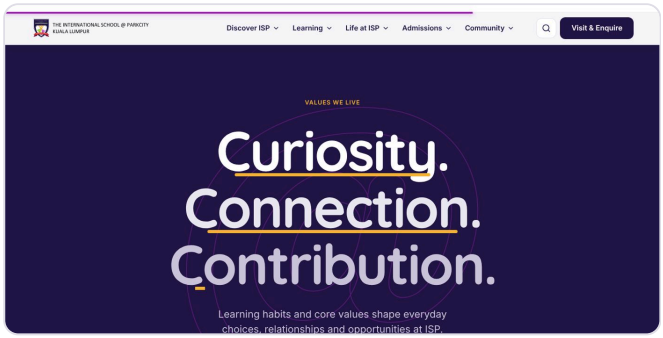
Research: spatial explorer (wheel, drag, depth).



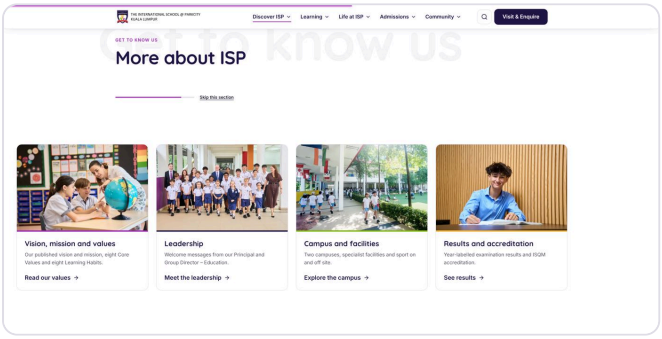
Built: scroll- and drag-driven helix, no visible controls, fixed caption.



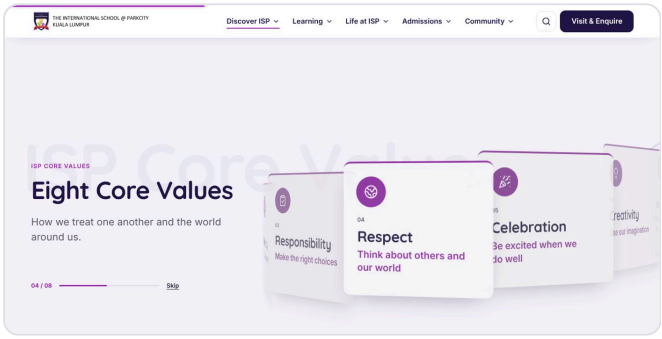
Research: stacked titles exiting sideways. Built, then dropped.



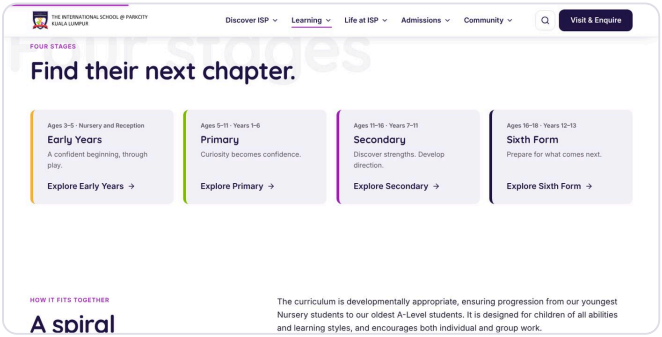
Built replacement: lit statement, words brighten in turn.



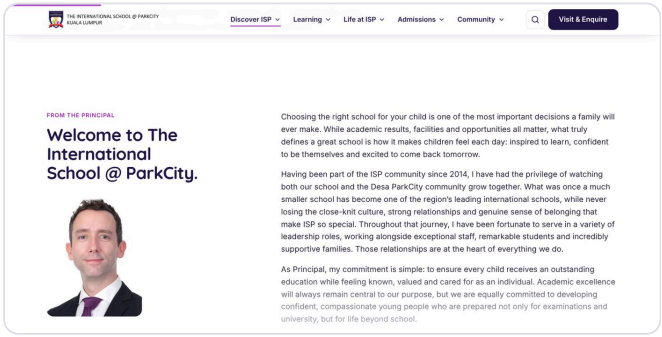
Sideways chapter aligned to the content edge; pins only when it overflows.



New: term spiral (icon, term, tagline).



New: faint background label drifting behind a still heading.



New: sticky aside and Read more.

09 / LAYOUT STABILITY

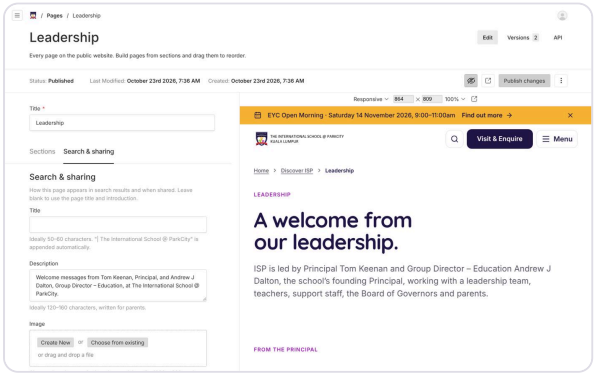
Nothing jumps, nothing is lost

- **RULE** Variable text in animated components sits in fixed slots (height, line clamp, fixed rows). Cycling every state must not move the next section.
- **RULE** Images declare width and height and sit in aspect-ratio frames, with a focal point for crops. Media frames are never empty.
- **RULE** Pinned scenes compute their length from measured overflow, re-measure on resize, fonts and images, and never pin when there is nothing to move.
- **RULE** No horizontal page scroll at any width: clip decorative overflow on `main`; only tables and code scroll inside their own boxes.
- **RULE** Server and browser render identical markup (no hydration mismatch). Components that read the URL also accept static-file addresses (`/page.html`).
- **RULE** The first hero never animates in, and its main image is preloaded (fast largest paint).

10 / THE CONTENT EDITOR

Editors are users too

- **Block-based pages:** add, reorder (drag), duplicate and remove sections; every visual option (spiral or grid, sideways row or grid, letter or plain text) is a labelled choice.
- **Drafts and publishing:** autosave drafts; an explicit Publish; version history with restore; expiry dates for banners and events.
- **Live preview:** the real page beside the form at phone, tablet and desktop sizes; drafts visible only to signed-in staff.
- **Roles:** Contributor (drafts only), Editor (publish, menus), Specialist (for example admissions or sales: enquiries, events, prices), Administrator (everything, staff). The last administrator cannot be demoted.
- **Media library:** alt text, approval status, release reference, focal point, automatic web sizes.
- **Shared settings:** edited once and reused (contacts, locations, prices, menus, announcement).
- **Enquiries:** created only by the site's forms; a status workflow; never readable through the public API.
- **Security:** no public sign-up; lockout after 5 failures for 15 minutes; 8-hour sessions; optional single sign-on or network restriction for `/admin`.
- **Hand-over:** a plain-English editor guide, a visual tour of real screens, and a "who approves what" table.



Editor live preview: the form on the left, the real page on the right.

11 / RESPONSIVE

Every width designed, not squeezed

Width	Behaviour (defaults)
≥ ~1360px	Full navigation with click-to-open menus. Pinned scenes active when they overflow.
1024–1359px	Menu button before any label wraps (find the exact breakpoint by testing the longest labels). Pinned scenes still active if the window is at least ~640px tall.
768–1023px	Snap swipe rows instead of pins; two-column grids.
< 768px	Single column; sticky bottom primary action with space reserved; tighter spiral; no background labels; swipe rows from the content edge.

CHECK 320, 390, 412, 768, 820, 1024, 1366, 1440 and 1920–2000px; portrait and landscape tablets; long titles; 200% zoom; the client's own device *and* viewer (for example an iPad inside a chat or email app).

12 / ACCESSIBILITY AND REDUCED MOTION

Same content, every way in

- Honour `prefers-reduced-motion` in CSS and JavaScript, live: no pinning, parallax, spiral turning, drifting labels or bands. Everything stays in normal flow.
- Buttons for actions, links for navigation; 44×44px targets; a visible 3px focus ring (a highlight colour on dark bands).
- Signature scenes keep a semantic list; galleries are keyboard reachable; skip links pass every pinned section; scrollable regions are focusable.
- Decorative duplicates (rolling text, background labels, ornaments) are hidden from assistive technology and drawn as CSS-generated content where scanners would read them as text.
- Dialogs: native modal, inert background, Escape closes, focus restored. Live regions for changing captions and form status.
- Forms: real labels, validation on blur, an error summary, answers kept on error, spam controls without CAPTCHAs, consent-gated analytics and maps.
- Zero serious or critical axe violations on representative pages after reveals settle.

13 / PERFORMANCE, SECURITY, HOSTING AND PREVIEWS

Fast first, then rich

- Responsive WebP sizes (about 400/800/1400/2200) and a 1200×630 share image; `sizes` per component; preload only the first hero image.
- Lazy-load below the fold, **except** inside moving or pinned scenes (load eagerly there).
- Animate transform and opacity only; requestAnimationFrame loops stop when settled; one scroll owner.
- Ship only the icons used; share one small validation schema between browser and server.
- Cache published content and invalidate it on publish; drafts bypass the cache.
- Security headers: a content security policy listing only the third parties actually used (consent-gated); `frame-ancestors 'self'`; force https and HSTS only when served over https; remove framework banners; validate and rate-limit every form and API.
- Targets: Lighthouse accessibility, best practices and SEO 100; performance at least 85 on mobile for key pages.

Hosting

A Node host, a PostgreSQL database, persistent or S3-type file storage, https, environment variables for secrets, a migration step on every deploy, backups, and staging before production. Document every setting in the README.

Static previews for review

When a build is shared as plain files (review links, artifact viewers): map server routes to files; build search from an exported index; make server-only features explain themselves; open every page at the top; retry dropped images; keep structured data byte-identical to avoid hydration mismatches; then crawl every link and image *in the copy* before sharing it.

14 / IMPLEMENTATION CONTRACT

Build it this way

- Semantic, server-rendered HTML first; progressive enhancement; content visible without JavaScript.
- One source of truth per scene (progress, selected item); the renderer is separate from the data.
- Tokens in one file; one component per block (schema + renderer); migrations for every schema change.
- Default stack (proven): Next.js with an embedded headless CMS (Payload), PostgreSQL, CSS modules, Playwright with axe, and Vitest. Any equivalent stack must meet the same contract.

```
// Sideways chapter
inner  = viewport.clientWidth - paddingLeft - paddingRight
D      = max(0, track.scrollWidth - inner)            // re-measure on resize, fonts, images
pinned = largeEnough && !reducedMotion && D > 0
outer.height = 100vh + D;   p = clamp((scrollY - outerTop) / D, 0, 1);   track.x = -D * p

// Helix position for item i, continuous position pos
d = shortestRingDistance(i, pos, count)              // 0 = front
x = sin(d*step)*R;  z = (cos(d*step) - 1)*R;  y = d*rise;  rotateY = d*step
current += (target - current) * (1 - exp(-dt / tau))  // tau 90-110ms; stop the loop when settled
```

From brief to launch

Phase	Output
1. Analyse	Read every input; list facts, gaps and conflicts; ask only what changes the build.
2. Architecture	Content model, block library, routes, roles and the motion trigger table, written down before building.
3. System	Tokens, type, layout, primitives, interaction language.
4. Build	Blocks, pages, signature scenes with fallbacks, forms, search, consent, SEO, 404.
5. Content	Seed real content and images from sources; sources register; placeholders labelled.
6. Prove	Run the full checklist (chapter 16) on a production build.
7. Show	A clickable preview the owner can open on their own device, plus an editor tour. Report results honestly.
8. Review rounds	Treat each round of owner feedback as rules: fix the cause rather than the symptom, re-run the checklist, re-publish to the same link, and summarise what changed and why.
9. Launch	Hosting, domain, https, backups, redirects, analytics consent, approvals of facts and photos, staff accounts, and an editor training session.

> **Review etiquette.** When feedback is short ("too much animation"), find the specific cause, remove it and replace it with a calmer alternative that keeps the intent. Don't just delete. When the owner reports something you can't reproduce (a white page on their device), remove the most likely causes, say plainly what couldn't be verified, and ask them to re-check.

16 / ACCEPTANCE CHECKLIST

Done means proven

Static analysis	Lint and type-check clean.
Unit tests	Validation, consent, rate limiting, search, slugs and redirects.
End-to-end	Navigation, menus, search, forms, consent, gallery keys, Read more, editor roles and preview, on desktop and mobile, against a production build.
Accessibility	Axe: zero serious or critical issues on representative pages.
Overflow and stability	No horizontal scroll at any listed width; cycling animated states moves nothing outside the component.
Link and image crawl	Every link (including script-opened menus) resolves; every image loads at desktop and phone widths, on the exact link being shared.
Hydration	No hydration warnings in production or previews.
Reduced motion	Every scene readable and usable.
Real devices	iOS Safari, Android Chrome, and the owner's viewer.
Editor	Draft, preview, publish, restore; each role can do exactly what it should.
Disclosure	Unfinished items, placeholders and unverified facts listed.

17 / PASTE-READY PROMPT

Give an AI this

```
Build a professional website and a block-based content editor for [CLIENT] using the attached facts, brand
assets, information architecture and reference notes. Follow the attached Master Website Brief; my own words
override it. Never invent facts: label anything unconfirmed and keep a sources register.

Direction: calm, editorial and purposeful. Make the subject understandable before it is spectacular. Use the
client's real photographs and brand colours by role. The site should feel alive, with motion in the
background: headings fade up once and then stay still; ambient motion comes from faint oversized background
labels, gentle photo parallax and sticky asides.

Signature scenes, at most one per page:
1. Hero spiral gallery turned by page scroll, drag and arrow keys; no visible gallery buttons; fixed two-line
   caption; a scroll-cue arrow.
2. One sideways chapter that pins only when its row overflows, aligned to the content edge; otherwise a
   native snap-scrolling row.
3. A lit statement where words brighten in turn with an underline, slowly; nothing slides sideways.
Lists of values or features: icon + term + one line (optional term spiral). Long text: "Read more" with a down
arrow. Sticky portrait beside letters. A single-colour reading progress line.

Never: move headings sideways with scroll; hide images behind clip-path curtains; use page transitions; use
multi-hue progress bars; let any link reach a missing page; let animated text change the page layout.

Deliver: tokens, component map, motion trigger table, editor (drafts, live preview, roles, versions, media
approvals), migrations, editor guide and tour, sources register, a clickable preview I can open on my own
device, and evidence of every acceptance check. Tell me plainly what is unfinished or unverified.
```

Where this comes from

- **Website Design Research: Editorial clarity, spatial motion, purposeful products** (22 October 2026): five live references, the storytelling model, three motion levels, the horizontal-chapter model and access requirements. The starting point for chapters 02, 03, 07, 08, 12 and 14.
- **A full build** (Next.js, Payload CMS, PostgreSQL; 31 pages, 25 block types), October 2026: every "proven" value is implemented and covered by 74 automated end-to-end tests with axe scans, overflow checks at nine widths, and link and image crawls of a shared static preview.
- **Owner review rounds**, 23 October 2026: the rules in chapter 04.

> **Limits.** Device-specific problems reported by the owner (a white page and missing images on an iPad viewer) were fixed by removing their likely causes; they were not reproduced in automation. Reference sites were studied from rendered behaviour, not their code. Every value here is a proven starting point: tune it to each brand and re-test.

Typefaces in this document: Quicksand and Inter (SIL Open Font License). Reference images: *Website Design Research*, 22 October 2026. Build images: example implementation, 23 October 2026.